

WORD RECOGNITION: VARIOUS STRATEGIES



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4.1 INTRODUCTION

Early literacy refers to the range of skills, attitudes, and understandings that help children engage with reading and writing in meaningful ways. As highlighted in *The Bloomsbury Handbook of Reading: Perspectives and Practices*, reading is not just the mechanical act of sounding out letters (Ewing, 2020, pp. 3–16). It is a **process of making meaning** that begins from the earliest experiences children have with language and communication.

Children begin developing early literacy long before they enter school. They “read” their surroundings through conversation, songs, rhymes, storytelling, play, and observation. These experiences build the foundation for later reading and writing. Research identifies three key factors that strongly support early literacy:

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- **Rich oral language interactions:** Frequent conversations with adults and peers that introduce new words, encourage questions, and build narrative skills.
- **Access to varied and culturally relevant books:** Opportunities to engage with print materials that reflect the child's own world and also introduce new ideas.
- **Interactive read-aloud sessions:** Teacher- or caregiver-led reading that involves discussion, questioning, and repetition to strengthen vocabulary, comprehension, and print awareness.

In multilingual contexts such as India, early literacy development should make use of the languages children already know. Building on these languages not only affirms children's identities but also supports the transfer of literacy skills into English and other school languages.

For teacher educators and trainers, it is important to emphasise that early literacy is not limited to letter drills or memorisation of words. It is a broad, integrated process that connects listening, speaking, reading, and writing. A strong early literacy foundation prepares learners to move confidently into the more formal skills of **word recognition**, phonemic awareness, and decoding—areas that are the focus of this chapter.

When children begin school, they do not start with reading and writing. They start by exploring sounds, visuals, gestures, rhythms, and relationships. Literacy, especially in a second language like English, is a developmental process that grows as we move from oral to the written language, from exploring the language to meaning-making in the language.

In the previous chapter we have read the **Four-Block Framework** (NCF-FS 2022) that recognises this continuum and recommends a balanced approach to foundational literacy. While each block, i.e. Oral Language, Word Recognition, Reading with Comprehension, Writing, is distinct, they work together holistically. Oral language supports word recognition, which in turn enhances comprehension and written expression.

4.1.1 Focus on Word Recognition in English as a Second Language

This chapter explores **Word Recognition** in the context of teaching **English as a second language** in Grades 1–5. Word recognition includes phonemic awareness, letter recognition, sound-symbol association, phonics, and



vocabulary. All of these form the foundation for fluent reading.

In multilingual classrooms, where children often speak one or more Indian languages at home, English may be the only language not encountered in natural settings. This increases the importance of intentional, classroom-based word recognition teaching. While all examples and discussions in this chapter use English as the target language, the concepts and strategies are transferable across all second language contexts. For example, the ability to isolate beginning sounds, or link letters to sounds, is equally critical in Hindi, Urdu, Tamil, or Marathi. Teachers are encouraged to adapt the pedagogical approaches shared here to the second language taught in their classroom.

Table 4.1: Contextual Application across Grades

Grade	Word Recognition Focus	Example
Grade 1	Beginning phonemic awareness, letter-sound link	Match pictures to sounds (e.g., /m/ for mango)
Grade 3	Phonics pattern recognition and decoding CVC/CVCC	Identify -ight words: light, sight, night
Grade 5	Fluency with multisyllabic words and high-frequency phrases	Read and highlight sight words in a simple news article

Teachers must vary the depth and scaffolding of activities depending on grade level, prior exposure to English, and the cognitive maturity of learners.

Do You Know?

- By the end of Grade 1, fluent readers typically recognise over 1,000 words automatically. This automaticity comes not from rote memorisation but from rich, repeated exposure to meaningful print.
- NEP 2020 states that the “ability to read with understanding” must be achieved by Grade 3. Children are expected to “learn to read” until Grade 3; beyond that, they must “read to learn.” If not achieved, learning gaps widen
- Yet ASER (n.d.) reports show that many children in Grade 5 cannot read a simple sentence in English. This makes the systematic teaching of word recognition a critical equity issue.

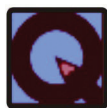


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**4.2 LEARNING OUTCOMES**

After completion of this chapter, the learner:

- Describes and explains key sub-skills of word recognition;
- Applies phonics-based and story-based strategies;
- Analyses story-driven and poetry-based strategies;
- Evaluates instructional groupings and justify multimodal approaches;
- Designs an integrated instructional unit on word recognition.

**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 4.1**

1. Which of the five learning outcomes mentioned above do you feel most confident about? Why?
2. Which one would you need to practice or explore further?
3. Think of a student you've worked with (real or hypothetical). How do you think their language background influenced their learning and how did you approach word recognition teaching to them?

4.3 WHY WORD RECOGNITION MATTERS IN EARLY LITERACY

The *Nipun Bharat* guidelines highlight that foundational literacy encompasses a range of interdependent skills: oral language development, phonological awareness, decoding, vocabulary, fluency, comprehension, and print concepts. Word recognition is the entry point to this cluster of skills. Without systematic teaching of phonics, high-frequency vocabulary, and decoding practice, learners risk depending on rote memorisation. A balanced approach, which combines phonics instruction with meaning-making, story telling, and comprehension-oriented activities, is, therefore, essential.

Goodman (1967/2021) describes reading as a “psycholinguistic guessing game,” (p. 13) where learners draw on predictions and confirm them against print. This reinforces why word recognition must be embedded in meaningful contexts rather than treated as a mechanical drill. Similarly, Smith (1973/2021) shows that comprehension often guides recognition, reminding us that children’s attempts at reading should always be tied to making sense of the text (p. 27-52).



In early stages of language learning, the difference between a child becoming a reader and a child remaining a non-reader often lies in their ability to **recognise words**, not through rote memorisation, but through understanding how **sounds connect to symbols** and how words behave in stories, in instructions, and daily language use.

Word recognition is the foundation for fluent, independent reading. When children can identify words automatically, their cognitive energy is freed up to think about meaning, make predictions, and engage with the text more deeply.

In the context of English as a second language, word recognition must be taught with special care. Most children will not encounter English print outside school. They may hear it spoken on television or in announcements, but they need structured classroom experiences to connect spoken English to written English.

What is Word Recognition?

Word recognition includes several interrelated sub-skills:

- **Phonemic awareness** : hearing and isolating sounds in words (oral)
- **Letter recognition**: identifying letters and their shapes
- **Sound–symbol mapping**: matching sounds to letters or letter combinations
- **Decoding**: blending sounds to form a word (e.g., /c/ /a/ /t/ = cat)
- **Sight word recognition**: recognising common words instantly without decoding (e.g., the, is, was)

These sub-skills work together to allow a child to read both familiar and unfamiliar words independently.

Why Word Recognition is Crucial—Especially in Second Language Contexts

1. English is irregular and complex

Unlike languages like Hindi or Kannada, English has many exceptions (e.g., “one” begins with /w/, not /o/). Without understanding patterns, learners may feel confused or frustrated.

2. Similar-looking letters cause confusion

Young learners often mix up letters such as b/d or p/q, especially when they lack

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prior exposure to printed English.

3. Lack of home support for English literacy

Many learners in Indian classrooms grow up in rich oral traditions in their home languages, but do not see English newspapers, books, or signs at home. Teachers must act as both guides and bridges to the world of English print.

Real Classroom Scenario: Grade 1

Saira, a 6-year-old in a multilingual classroom in West Bengal, knows the names of animals in English. But when she sees the word ‘cat’, she pauses. She guesses: “Cuh... ah... tuh?”

Her teacher realises that while Saira can say the word ‘cat’, she has not yet internalised how **sounds make words**. She needs support in **blending, repetition, and pattern recognition**.

Word recognition in Grade 1 must begin with **oral phonemic work**, letter naming, and **decodable words** drawn from stories and songs.

Real Classroom Scenario: Grade 3

A teacher introduces a shared reading text called “A Day in the Park”. It includes words like morning, swinging, sunshine. Some learners easily decode morning and sunshine, while others stumble.

The teacher realises these learners know simple CVC words (bat, mat) but struggle with compound or multisyllabic words. The teacher creates a word-building station with puzzles like:

- sun + shine = sunshine
- swing + ing = swinging

In Grade 3, learners need support moving beyond basic phonics to **recognising familiar chunks**, prefixes, and compound words.

Real Classroom Scenario: Grade 5

In a Grade 5 classroom, children read a short article about water conservation. The teacher notices some learners skipping over words like evaporation and absorption. Rather than ignoring them, she stops and leads a discussion:

- “What smaller word do you see inside evaporation?”
- “Can we say it slowly together?”

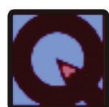


She also adds these words to a **classroom word wall**, revisiting them during science lessons.

In Grade 5, children must begin applying word recognition strategies to **subject-specific texts** and **authentic materials**, integrating language learning with content learning.

Do You Know?

Only about 50% of English words are spelt as they sound. The remaining require learners to recognise patterns or recall words by sight. This means phonics alone is not enough—exposure, repetition, and context are just as important, and all these exercises must be accompanied with stories, poetry, play, painting and conversations.

**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 4.3**

1. Match the description to the sub-skill:

Statement	Subskill
i “This child can clap out the sounds in ‘dog’.”	A. Phonemic Awareness
ii “This child can name the letter ‘d’.”	B. Letter Recognition
iii “This child knows that ‘d’ makes the /d/ sound.”	C. Sound–Symbol Association
iv “This child reads ‘was’ without sounding it out.”	D. Sight Word Recognition

2. Think of a learner (real or imagined) in each of the following grades:

- Grade 1: What are they likely struggling with in word recognition?
- Grade 3: What kind of texts might challenge them?
- Grade 5: How does vocabulary complexity affect their reading fluency?

3. Write a paragraph describing what tailored support you would offer at each grade level.

Answer:

1. i-A, ii- B, iii- C, iv- D



4.4 KEY CONCEPTS IN WORD RECOGNITION

Word recognition is built upon three foundational concepts:

- i. phonemic awareness
- ii. letter recognition
- iii. sound–symbol association

These concepts may seem basic, but they form the intricate mental scaffolding on which fluent reading is built. Even if one of these foundations is weak, a learner may develop reading habits based on guessing, skipping, or rote memorisation.

Young readers take cues from semantics, syntax, and graphophonics when tackling print. For classroom practice, this means word recognition is not merely letter–sound matching but a process that must engage multiple cueing systems. Newman (1985/2021) further illustrates that fluency depends equally on visual information and the reader’s prior knowledge, suggesting that background experiences are as vital as decoding accuracy (p. 64-78).

In the second language classroom, especially where English is not the home language, each of these components must be taught explicitly, intentionally, and repeatedly through **playful, meaningful, and story-rich interactions**. Children learn most effectively in a language they already know. Thus, in multilingual classrooms, home and community languages must be seen as resources rather than barriers. Teachers should explicitly connect letter–sound patterns in English with familiar sound systems from children’s home languages. Such cross-linguistic scaffolding strengthens phonemic awareness and prevents confusion in the early stages of reading.

4.4.1 Phonemic Awareness: Hearing the Building Blocks of Words

Phonemic awareness is the ability to hear, isolate, and manipulate the smallest units of sound—**phonemes**—in spoken words. It is an auditory skill, not a visual one, and is the gateway to decoding.

Children with strong phonemic awareness can:

- Identify beginning, middle, and ending sounds
- Blend phonemes to form words
- Segment spoken words into individual sounds
- Substitute one sound for another to form new words



This is a pre-print/pre-literacy skills. It should be fully developed through oral activities before introducing letter–sound mapping.

Grade 1 Example:

Teacher: Let's play the sound game. What's the first sound in *ball*?

Children: /b/!

Teacher: [plays the Switch-a-sound game] If I change the /b/ in bat to /h/, what do I get?

Children: Hat!

Tip: Use clapping, tapping, and singing to make phoneme games fun and memorable. Avoid written words at this stage.

Grade 3 Example:

Children work in small groups with picture cards. Each group sorts words by their ending sound:

- Group A: *cap, map, lap*
- Group B: *cat, mat, hat*

Tip: Build phonemic awareness into spelling patterns and word families. This reinforces decoding and vocabulary together.

Grade 5 Example:

The class plays Phoneme Detective while reading a science text. They underline all words with the /sh/ sound and sort them into 'sh', 'ti', and 'ci' spellings:

- *Shape, station, social*

Tip: Apply phonemic awareness to complex texts and less obvious phoneme-grapheme links to reinforce decoding flexibility.

Do You Know?

Research (Stanovich, 1986) shows that phonemic awareness is the strongest predictor of reading success, more than IQ or vocabulary. In multilingual settings, this awareness in the home language often transfers—but only if the teacher builds on it.

*Notes***CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 4.3**

You say: “Let’s break the word ‘cat’.” What responses would show that a child is:

- Aware of syllables but not phonemes?
- Guessing rather than segmenting?
- Confusing phonemes with letter names?

Write your own analysis.

4.4.2 Letter Recognition: Knowing the Visual Symbols of Language

Letter recognition refers to the ability to:

- Identify both uppercase and lowercase letters
- Name them accurately
- Differentiate visually similar letters ((e.g.: *b, d, p, q*)
- Associate their shape with a spoken name

It is not just about knowing the alphabet—it is about forming a reliable visual memory system for written language.

Grade 1 Example:

The teacher uses sandpaper letters. Children trace and chant:

“This is big B. B says /b/. B for ball.”

Each day, a new “Letter of the Day” is explored through pictures, songs, and hands-on materials.

Tip: Use tactile and visual resources—clay, sand trays, flashcards—to reinforce shape and form of letters.

Grade 3 Example:

Students play a Letter Shape Relay. They match uppercase to lowercase forms and sort letters by characteristics:

- Tall letters: *b, d, h*
- Short letters: *a, e, n*
- Letters with tails: *g, j, y*

Tip: Reinforce recognition through word building and sentence construction. Add letter sorting to reinforce visual distinctions.

Grade 5 Example:

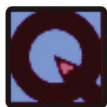
Children use alphabet grids during dictionary tasks. They are asked:

- “Find a word beginning with ‘g’.”
- “Can you sort these into alphabetical order?”

Tip: Reinforce letter recognition through application—dictionaries, indexes, labels, and form filling.

Do You Know?

Many Indian scripts are phonetic and highly regular. Children may find English letter forms “illogical” or confusing. Introducing cross-script comparisons (e.g., ‘क’ and ‘K’ both mean a similar sound) helps bridge understanding.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 4.4

Create a mini activity to assess:

- Whether children know both cases (upper and lower)
- Whether they can name and sound each letter

Try it with two different grades (e.g., 1 and 3) and note the differences in approach and understanding.

4.4.3 Sound–Symbol Association: Connecting Sounds with Letters

Sound–symbol association (also known as **grapheme–phoneme correspondence**) is the bridge from **oral language to print**. It refers to a child’s ability to associate a spoken sound with the letter(s) that represent it in writing.

This is the first step toward **decoding**—translating print into spoken language. English presents special challenges because:

- Some letters make multiple sounds (e.g., c in cat vs. circle)
- Some sounds can be written in multiple ways (e.g., /f/ as in fan, ph as in phone)



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Grade 1 Example:

The teacher says the /s/ sound and shows three cards:

- Sun
- Ask
- Bus

Children identify the beginning, middle, and ending positions of the sound.

Tip: Focus on common consonant sounds and short vowels. Use familiar, concrete vocabulary.

Grade 3 Example:

Students work on a digraph match-up. Each pair must match a sound to its letter combo:

- /ch/ – chop, chair
- /sh/ – shop, fish
- /th/ – thin, this

Tip: Introduce less transparent sound-symbol associations through categorisation, games, and phonics readers.

Grade 5 Example:

In a social studies lesson, students read the word 'nation.' The teacher underlines **tion** and asks:

The teacher: What sound do these letters make?

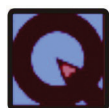
Children: /shun/!

They then brainstorm: station, action, motion.

Tip: Emphasise morphemes and pronunciation rules in multisyllabic words. Encourage independent word investigation.

Do You Know?

English has 26 letters but 44 sounds, which makes sound-symbol association more complex than in most Indian languages. Learners require repeated exposure across listening, speaking, reading, and writing modalities to master this.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 4.4

Choose a sound such as /ch/ or /sh/. Ask learners to:

- Say three words beginning with that sound.
- Circle or underline the letters that represent that sound in print.
- Write one sentence using at least one such word.

Evaluate whether the learner understands both production and print representation.



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4.5 PHONICS AND LETTER–SOUND MAPPING FOR DIVERSE LEARNERS

Phonics is the method by which children learn to **decode written words** by linking the sounds (phonemes) of spoken language to the letters (graphemes) that represent them. It is an essential step between sound–symbol association and independent reading.

In second language classrooms, phonics instruction must be both systematic and contextual. Learners cannot rely on home exposure to reinforce these connections. Teachers must intentionally design repeated, engaging, and meaningful interactions with sound–letter patterns.

NCF-FS 2022 states that children must be taught to decode written language using meaningful patterns and engaging stories-not isolated drill (pp. 112-117).

Why is Phonics Critical?

- English has irregular spellings and multiple phoneme–grapheme mappings (e.g., *phone*, *knight*, *write*).
- Phonics allows learners to move beyond memorising words to decoding them.
- It builds confidence and autonomy in reading.
- It supports spelling and vocabulary acquisition.

Grade 1 Example: First Phonics Patterns

Children are introduced to CVC (**consonant–vowel–consonant**) words through a rhyme:

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♪ “I see a cat,
Sitting on a mat.
It saw a rat,
And that was that!”

Each day, the teacher introduces one new ‘at’ sound word. Children blend the sounds using letter tiles: /c/ + /a/ + /t/ = cat

Tip: Begin with clear, simple sounds that have a 1:1 sound-letter relationship. Use rhyme, song, and manipulatives to maintain interest.

Grade 3 Example: Word Families and Digraphs

At this stage, learners can move from basic phonics to **pattern recognition**. The teacher introduces **word families** (-ing, -ight, -ake) and **digraphs** (ch, sh, th).

Activity: “Sort the Words!”

Each group receives a mixed set of cards:

- Words: chip, chin, ship, shut, thin, thick
- Task: Group by beginning sound and then create a tongue twister with the group.

Tip: Introduce sorting and classification to support decoding and vocabulary expansion simultaneously.

Grade 5 Example: Multisyllabic Word Decoding

In Grade 5, learners begin encountering **multisyllabic words** in textbooks. The teacher focuses on breaking them into **syllables** and **morphemes**.

Example: evaporation

- Syllables: e-vap-o-ra-tion
- Sound out each part
- Identify root word: vapour

Activity: Create a “big word map” of compound and scientific words seen in class.

Tip: Phonics at this level supports content learning in subjects like science and



social studies. Encourage curiosity about how words are built.

Techniques for Effective Phonics Teaching

1. Synthetic Phonics

- Teach individual letters and their sounds.
- Blend to form words: /s/ /a/ /t/ = sat

2. Analytic Phonics

- Start with whole words, then analyse parts: boat → b + oat

3. Embedded Phonics

- Teach within real texts: highlight sh words while reading a poem about fish.

4. Multisensory Phonics

- Use touch (sandpaper letters), movement (air writing), sound (songs), and sight (charts).

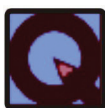
Across all methods, consistency and reinforcement are keys. One exposure is never enough. Over-reliance on a single method, such as phonics drills, is not advisable. Instead, a balanced approach that integrates phonics with whole-language and comprehension-based strategies. For example, phonics can be reinforced through shared reading of stories, big books, and rhymes, ensuring that decoding is always tied to meaning. This prevents the teaching of phonics from becoming mechanical or decontextualised. Shobha Sinha (2009/2021)'s analysis of Indian primers reveals that when phonics dominates without attention to meaning, children may decode but fail to comprehend. This underscores the need for phonics to be integrated with stories and purposeful texts (pp. 53-63). Thompson (2021) adds that while explicit phonics instruction is valuable, research shows it is most effective when woven together with vocabulary development and comprehension strategies (pp. 79-87).

Do You Know?

English has 176 graphemes that represent its 44 phonemes. A single sound can have up to 10 different spellings (e.g., /ai/ as in rain, day, steak, great). Explicit instruction and visual memory are essential for success.



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**CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING 4.5**

1. Design a brief phonics session for one of the following grades:

Grade	Focus	Task
1	CVC words (-an, -it, -op)	Build and blend using letter tiles
3	Digraphs (ch, th, sh)	Sort pictures by sound and create a sentence
5	Syllable decoding	Break information into syllables and the root word

2. Reflect:

- i. What challenges might learners face?
- ii. How will you scaffold decoding without overwhelming them?

4.6 STORY-BASED VOCABULARY AND HIGH-FREQUENCY WORD PRACTICE

Why Story-Based Vocabulary Works

Children do not learn language in fragments; they learn it in meaningful, emotionally resonant contexts. Stories are naturally structured around familiar themes, predictable patterns, and repetitive vocabulary, making them ideal for teaching new words—especially high-frequency ones that don't always follow phonetic rules (e.g., *the*, *was*, *said*, *of*).

When children encounter words repeatedly in stories, they begin to associate **sound, spelling, and meaning**, which builds both **decoding fluency** and **semantic understanding**.

NCF-FS advocates using stories and poetry as vehicles of language acquisition especially for second language learners to ensure emotional connection, contextual reinforcement, and meaningful repetition (pp. 145-147).

Grade 1 Example: Repetition and Rhyming Support

Story: "*The Lost Hat*"

Text excerpt: "Raju had a red hat. He wore it on his head. One day, it flew away!"



Key words: hat, red, head, flew, away

The teacher reads aloud and pauses for prediction:

- “What colour was the hat?”
- “Where was it?”
- “Let’s act it out!”

The same words appear in flashcards, drawing sheets, and an end-of-week mini book: “*I see a red hat.*”

Tip: Grade 1 learners benefit from oral repetition, choral reading, and picture-supported vocabulary practice.

Grade 3 Example: Expanding Word Families from Stories

Story: “The Forest Picnic”

Words introduced: basket, blanket, biscuits, bottle, butterflies

Activity: Children create a **vocabulary web** after reading. The teacher uses story scenes to elicit sentence creation:

- “The biscuits are in the basket.”
- “I sit on the blanket.”

They then play “*Pick a Word*”-choose a word from the web and either act it out or draw it.

Tip: In Grade 3, move from labelling to **structured sentence frames**, reinforcing grammar and decoding.

Grade 5 Example: Applying Vocabulary in Content Areas

Story: “The Great Flood” (adapted historical fiction)

Words: river, rescue, danger, shouted, heavy, help

After the reading, learners:

- Identify which words are nouns, verbs, and adjectives
- Use a **context clue strategy**: find the sentence that helps define rescue
- Write a short paragraph using at least 4 story words

Tip: Grade 5 students can begin using strategies (e.g., context clues, morpheme

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analysis) to expand and apply vocabulary independently.

Integrating High-Frequency Words

High-frequency words make up more than 50% of early texts, but many of them (e.g., *the, you, of, was*) are irregular and must be recognised on sight.

Rather than memorising lists, learners should:

- Encounter these words in predictable books and daily instructions
- Practice through movement, games, and cumulative story reading

Common Activities:

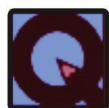
- **Sight Word Walk:** Tape flashcards on walls. Students walk and read aloud.
- **Rainbow Writing:** Trace a word in 3 different colours.
- **Word Wall Race:** Teacher says a word—students point to it on the word wall.

Table 4.2: examples of Story-Based Vocabulary Across Grades

Grade	Practice Method	Sample Words	Task
1	Label the classroom with sight words	the, is, my, it	"I see the fan." (draw + label)
3	Word wall + matching sentences	where, when, what, went	Complete: "I went to the _____."
5	Story text + vocabulary strategy	because, although, during, through	Write your own sentence; explain word use

Do You Know?

Dolch and Fry, researchers of high-frequency vocabulary, identified that just 100 sight words account for more than half the words in primary reading materials. Recognising these automatically frees up cognitive energy for comprehension.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 4.6

1. Choose a storybook or poem appropriate for one of your grades.
2. Identify:
 - 3–5 high-frequency or new vocabulary words
 - A pre-reading prediction or vocabulary activation task
 - A post-reading application activity (e.g., sentence making, acting out, mini-book)
3. Assess:
 - Did learners use the new words independently after two days?
 - Could they recognise them in other contexts?
4. How do stories and poems in your classroom support both decoding and vocabulary growth? Are you using them as one-time events or as anchors for building multiple literacy skills?



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4.7 SCAFFOLDING DECODING AND WORD KNOWLEDGE

What Does Scaffolding Mean?

In early language and literacy instruction, scaffolding refers to the temporary support that a teacher provides to help a learner accomplish a task just beyond their independent ability. Coined by Jerome Bruner and aligned with Vygotsky's Zone of Proximal Development, scaffolding involves:

- **Modelling** the task
- **Guided practice** with cues
- **Gradual release** toward independence

In decoding, scaffolding helps children move from halting, effortful reading to fluent and confident word recognition. For second language learners, such support is especially vital, as they may not be familiar with English spelling patterns or vocabulary.

Scaffolding should decrease over time as the learner becomes more capable, but should intensify when new patterns, exceptions, or multisyllabic words are introduced.

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Grade 1 Example: Beginning Blenders

In a beginner classroom, children are decoding simple CVC (consonant-vowel-consonant) words. The teacher models:

- “This is *m* ... this is *a* ... this is *t*. When we say them together: *m-a-t*, we get *mat*.”

The teacher then:

- Invites children to try blending with word cards
- Asks them to build new words by swapping one sound (e.g., *mat* → *cat* → *hat* → *bat*)
- Uses **Elkonin boxes** or syllable boxes with counters to represent each sound

Tip: Visual and tactile aids help Grade 1 children track sound-to-letter matches. Frequent repetition in shared reading texts builds confidence.

Grade 3 Example: Digraph and Word Family Decoding

In a Grade 3 class, the teacher introduces the digraph /sh/. The teacher writes a mystery sentence on the board:

- “The ___ is in the ___. It goes ___!”

Students must decode: fish, dish, shh.

The teacher:

- Breaks each word into sounds
- Shows pictures as prompts
- Encourages the group to build their own “sh” sentences

Later, students play **Word Ladder** games (e.g., ship → shop → chop → chip).

Tip: Provide just enough support (e.g., beginning sound, picture clue) to help learners self-correct and persevere. Encourage playful decoding.

Grade 5 Example: Multisyllabic and Content Vocabulary

In a science-integrated lesson, the teacher introduces words like:

- Evaporation



- Condensation
- Precipitation

The teacher scaffolds by:

1. **Segmenting** into syllables: e-va-po-ra-tion
2. Identifying **base/root words**: vapor
3. Using **morpheme analysis**: -tion = noun

Children then:

- Build a chart of root words and suffixes
- Create a 4-word science story using the vocabulary

Tip: In Grade 5, decoding involves strategic thinking. Scaffolding helps learners recognise patterns, not just pronounce words.

Table 4.3: Scaffolding Strategies Across Levels

Strategy	Description	Example
Modelling	The teacher reads aloud and tracks each word	“I see the /s/ in sun here.”
Think-Aloud	The teacher verbalises the decoding process	“This word starts with /tr/. Let’s try blending.”
Prompting	The teacher offers partial cues	“What’s the first sound in this word?”
Shared Reading	Class reads from the big book together	Teacher guides phrasing and decoding
Peer Pairing	A stronger reader helps a peer	In mixed-ability groups

Tools for Scaffolding Decoding

- **Letter Tiles and Magnets:** Moveable letters for building words
- **Word Wheels:** Rotating spinners to change onset and rime
- **Sound Sorting Games:** Categorising words/pictures by beginning or ending sounds
- **Phonics Flip Books:** Foldable booklets to practice word families and patterns

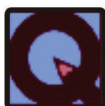
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- **Interactive Word Walls:** High-frequency and phonics-based words for quick reference
- **Important:** Scaffolds are not crutches—they are bridges to independence.

Do You Know?

Cognitive science shows that decoding fluency (the ability to read words accurately and automatically) is a major predictor of comprehension. Without fluency, children use most of their brainpower just decoding words—leaving little room for understanding or engagement.

**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 4.7**

Observe or plan a decoding session for any grade. Record:

1. What scaffolds were provided?
2. Did the learner guess, decode, or memorise the word?
3. How could support be adjusted to promote greater independence?

Then, create a 10-minute mini-lesson plan for one of the following:

- Grade 1: CVC decoding with Elkonin boxes
- Grade 3: Word ladder with digraphs
- Grade 5: Syllable breakdown of academic vocabulary

Note what are signs that a child is ready to read a word independently? What might happen if we remove scaffolds too early—or provide them for too long?

4.8 USING AUTHENTIC TEXTS AND POETRY IN GROUPED INSTRUCTION**Why Use Authentic Texts?**

Authentic texts are real-world materials written for purposes other than classroom instruction. These include:

- Storybooks
- Menus and signs



- Invitations, posters, labels
- Greeting cards
- Poems and rhymes
- Instructions and short news items

Using authentic texts is essential because they:

- Reflect how language is used outside school
- Provide contextual clues that aid word recognition
- Are engaging, familiar, and meaningful to learners
- Support the integrated development of decoding, vocabulary, and comprehension

NCF-FS (2022) encourages the use of print-rich, familiar, and functional texts that allow the learner to interact with English in real-world (pp. 77-79).

Grade 1 Example: Signs and Labels

Text Type: Classroom Labels & Birthday Cards

Children help label objects in the room: *fan, chair, mat, bag, wall*. The teacher also shows real birthday cards and asks:

- “Where is your name?”
- “What does this say?” (*Dear, Happy, Love*)

Later, children “write” their own cards by copying and tracing sight words: *To, From, Love*.

Tip: Use labelling and cards to introduce sight words in context. Children begin to “read” the room.

Grade 3 Example: Menus and Poetry

Text Type: Street Food Menu + Rhyming Poem

- Menu includes: *idli, dosa, rice, tea*
- Poem: “*Rice and spice, that’s nice!*”

Activity:

1. Children circle known words in a mock menu.

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2. They read and perform the poem in groups.
3. They write their own food rhyme.

“Dosa in my dish,

I make a wish!”

Tip: Connect literacy to familiar cultural texts. Poetry allows for playful engagement with rhythm, rhyme, and word recognition.

Grade 5 Example: Notices and Newspaper Snippets

Text Type: Public Notices + Short News Reports

Children read a notice:

“School closed on 2 October for Gandhi Jayanti.”

Then:

- Identify key words: closed, October, Gandhi
- Answer questions: “Why is the school closed?”, “Who is Gandhi?”

Later, they read a short children’s news item and highlight the following:

- Proper nouns
- Action verbs
- Connectors (because, and, then)

Tip: Use informational texts to practice decoding longer words, inferencing, and understanding functional vocabulary.

Table 4.4: Instructional Grouping Formats

Grouping	Best for	Examples
Whole-Class	Choral reading, poem performance	Recite “Twinkle Twinkle” with gestures
Small Groups	Collaborative reading, vocabulary work	Read and sort labels in a grocery store flyer
Individual	Differentiated tracing, writing tasks	Copy and illustrate 5 menu items with spelling support



Differentiated grouping allows the teacher to provide targeted support based on reading level, language confidence, and familiarity with print.

Real-Life Classroom Practice: Poetry in Performance (Grade 3)

The teacher introduces a short poem:

“Up in the sky,
The birds fly high.
They flap and glide,
And dip and slide.”

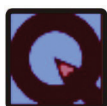
The class:

- Identifies rhyming words
- Claps pre
- Acts out actions
- Creates a visual storyboard

Impact: The same five high-frequency words are seen, heard, spoken, read, and enacted—deepening memory and understanding.

Do You Know?

Repeated reading of predictable poems not only builds decoding fluency but also improves oral prosody—the natural rhythm, stress, and intonation of language—which is a key component of fluent reading and a strong predictor of comprehension.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 4.8

Choose an authentic text that your students could engage with next week. It could be:

- A birthday invitation
- A street sign
- A local poem
- A children’s book

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Then answer:

1. Which words would learners be able to recognise or decode?
2. What pre-reading support would they need?
3. How could you use whole-class, small-group, and individual formats to explore the text?

Reflection Prompt:

Which types of authentic texts are most available in your school or community? How can you build a small “text-rich corner” using these? What could learners take home to reinforce classroom literacy?

4.9 DESIGNING AN INTEGRATED UNIT ON WORD RECOGNITION

Why Integrate?

Isolated drills can teach a phoneme. A rhyme may teach a few sight words. But only a thematic, integrated unit allows learners to:

- Apply new words across contexts
- Revisit and reinforce decoding patterns
- Use vocabulary in speaking, reading, and writing
- Experience reading as a joyful, purposeful activity

The National Curriculum Framework (NCF-FS 2022) suggests meaning-making environment that are not fragmented by skill silos (pp. 114-116). A child may first hear the word basket in a story, then spell it, draw it, and eventually use it in writing. Integration leads to internalisation.

An integrated unit on word recognition should reflect the meaning-making environment. For example, a thematic unit might begin with oral activities, move into phonics and vocabulary practice, and culminate in shared story reading or engaging with ‘authentic material’, drawing, and writing. Integration ensures that children encounter new words multiple times across oral, reading, and writing contexts, which accelerates internalisation.

Unit Planning Framework

Each unit in this section is structured by:

- **Theme:** Relevant, real-world topics
- **Focus Vocabulary:** Targeted phonics and sight words
- **Daily Activities:** Progressing from oral to written
- **Assessment:** Embedded, informal, and performance-based

Grade 1 Unit: Theme – My Pet

Day	Focus	Activity	Word Focus
Mon	Phonemic Awareness	Animal sound game: /d/ for dog, /c/ for cat	Initial consonants
Tue	Letter–Sound Mapping	Trace ‘d’, match to dog; write with finger in flour	d, c, b, f
Wed	Story-Based Vocabulary	Read “ <i>Rani’s Puppy</i> ”, circle <i>pet</i> , <i>dog</i> , <i>run</i>	pet, run, dog
Thu	High-Frequency Words	Sight word wall: <i>I</i> , <i>have</i> , <i>a</i> ; children write “I have a dog.”	I, have, a
Fri	Integration & Play	Draw and label pet; perform a rhyme: “I love my pet!”	All words above

Assessment Tip: Check for correct sound-letter connections and sentence construction. Use picture dictation (“Draw a cat. Write ‘cat.’”) to assess decoding.

Grade 3 Unit: Theme – At the Park

Day	Focus	Activity	Word Focus
Mon	Phoneme Blending	Clap and blend: swing, slide, grass	sw, sl, gr blends
Tue	Word Families	Build and sort -ing words: swinging, running, jumping	-ing family
Wed	Story + Digraphs	Read “The Picnic Day”; circle <i>ch</i> and <i>sh</i> words	chips, bench, children
Thu	Vocabulary Game	Create park sentence strips: “We sat on the bench.”	bench, park, mat
Fri	Poetry + Performance	Recite the class poem: “I jump, I swing, I slide”	fluency & phrasing



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Assessment Tip: Use group reading, a partner quiz on blends/digraphs, and a matching game to evaluate decoding and vocabulary retention.

Grade 5 Unit: Theme – Weather Watch

Day	Focus	Activity	Word Focus
Mon	Syllable Splitting	Break and count syllables: <i>evaporation, sunlight</i>	Multisyllabic words
Tue	Morpheme Analysis	Deconstruct: evaporation = vapor + tion; build new words	vapor, condensation
Wed	Reading Application	Read weather chart + report; underline tricky words	cloud, forecast, thunder
Thu	Vocabulary Strategy	Use context to guess new words: “The clouds were dark and ____.”	drizzle, heavy
Fri	Writing + Sharing	Write and present: “A Rainy Day” using 5 focus words	spelling, fluency, usage

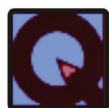
Assessment Tip: Use a self-checklist: “Did I use all 5 words?”, “Can decode a new weather word?”

Cross-Unit Planning Insights

- Start each day with oral or phonemic warm-ups.
- Recycle vocabulary through story, art, and physical movement.
- End with a reflective activity—drawing, speaking, or writing—to consolidate.
- Build **word walls** and **class dictionaries** as living resources.

Do You Know?

Research shows that thematic units improve retention because the brain naturally stores information connected to meaningful experiences, not isolated drills. Learners exposed to thematic word use across the week perform better in decoding and application.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 4.9

Choose a theme appropriate to your class (e.g., *My Home, Monsoon Time, On the Farm*). Plan a 3-day word recognition unit:

1. Day 1: Phonemic or letter-sound focus
2. Day 2: Story or poem integration
3. Day 3: Vocabulary use through drawing, acting, or writing

Checklist for Planning:

- Have you included high-frequency AND decodable words?
- Is the same word used in multiple contexts (read, say, write)?
- Is there at least one oral and one written output?

Reflect:

What scaffolds will you need to prepare in advance? How will you assess if learners are truly recognising and using new words?



4.10 LET US SUM UP

- The Word Recognition Block is more than just helping children “sound out” words. It is about empowering them to see, hear, say, and use words fluently and confidently in a second language like English. When taught intentionally, it becomes the bridge between early oral language and independent reading and writing.
- The three pillars of word recognition are Phonemic Awareness, which involves hearing and playing with individual sounds in spoken words; Letter Recognition, which is the ability to identify and name letters in both upper and lower case; and Sound–Symbol Association, which refers to mapping sounds to the letters that represent them. Together, these three components form the foundation for developing strong reading skills.
- Essential strategies for diverse classrooms include systematic and multisensory phonics instruction, meaningful story-based vocabulary exposure, and repetition and use of high-frequency words in context. They also involve scaffolding decoding using visual, verbal, and tactile prompts,



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as well as the integration of authentic texts, including menus, posters, and poems. These strategies support learners by making reading instruction more engaging, accessible, and effective.

- Application through thematic units can be seen in examples for Grades 1, 3, and 5, which demonstrate how to design week-long integrated plans, include activities across the Four Blocks, and embed informal assessments in daily routines. The Word Recognition block is not an isolated skill set; rather, it is a dynamic, integrative process that helps children move from “I can’t read” to “I love to read.”
- Early Literacy is understood as a broad, integrated process that links oral language, reading, and writing. Within this process, Word Recognition builds the bridge from spoken to written language. The key skills involved include phonemic awareness, letter recognition, sound–symbol association, phonics, and sight words.
- Instructional strategies include phonics routines, story-based learning, authentic text use, and scaffolding. With an equity focus, multilingual learners benefit greatly from connecting home language knowledge to English print skills. For maximum impact, word recognition activities should always be integrated with comprehension, oral language, and writing.

**4.11 END EXERCISES**

1. Define phonemic awareness, letter recognition, and sound-symbol association.
2. Explain how they differ and how they work together in fluent reading.
3. Choose a theme such as “Seasons”, “Wild Animals”, or “My Neighbourhood”. Design a three-day word recognition plan that includes:
 - A phonemic awareness activity
 - A letter–sound or decoding task
 - A story or poem-based vocabulary task

Also specify informal assessment indicators, such as drawing and labelling, matching tasks, or oral responses.

4. Observe or recall a classroom session focused on early reading. In 150 words, reflect on the following:



- What decoding supports were provided?
 - How were new words introduced?
 - Were children able to read, say, write, or draw the new vocabulary?
 - Was the word recognition block effectively addressed?
5. Select a storybook suitable for your learners, such as “Mina’s School Day” or “The Crow and the Pitcher”.
- Identify five vocabulary words that could be taught using the text.
 - Plan a pre-reading vocabulary activation task.
 - Plan a post-reading application task (e.g. sentence writing, drawing).
 - Suggest how you would check if learners can use the new words independently or recognise them in new contexts.
6. Write an essay: How does the Word Recognition block create a bridge between oral language and fluent reading in a second language? What changes would you consider making to your classroom practice to support this block more effectively?
7. Analyse the role of the Word Recognition block in moving learners from spoken to printed language.
8. Illustrate your ideas with an example from a classroom experience or observation.
9. Evaluate the impact of automatic word recognition on comprehension and engagement.
10. Propose specific, practical changes to your teaching that would strengthen this block.
11. Predict the benefits and possible challenges of implementing these changes.

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